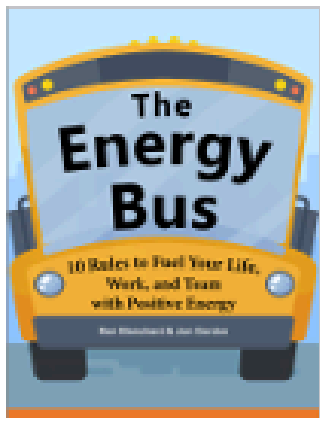




THE ENERGY BUS

10 Rules to Fuel Your Life, Work, and Team
with Positive Energy

Ken Blanchard & Jon Gordon



The Big “So What”

Through a fictional story about how a man overcame serious career and marital problems, the authors present 10 rules about using positive thinking and positive energy to create desired outcomes in life. The ideas are useful for anyone who wants to overcome challenges, build strong teams, and live a happy, fulfilling life.



Introduction



To succeed in your personal and professional life, you must learn to manage people’s energy, including your own. This book explains how to manage negativity and create positive energy to bring desired outcomes for yourself, your team/organization and your family.

- Research shows that positive thinking and communication create better results in various aspects of life—from personal health to family relationships, teamwork, and success. Positive energy in this book refers to the joy, passion, enthusiasm, optimism, and sense of purpose that allow us to live and perform at a higher level. It affects how you lead and build your teams at work, how you manage challenges and adversities in life, and how you interact with others around you. It determines if you allow negative forces to drag you down, or if can counter those forces to bring out the best in others and in yourself.
- Through a fictional story about a George—a middle manager struggling with a series of challenges at work and at home—the authors present 10 rules to help you harness positive energy to overcome problems and setbacks in life. In this summary, we’ll outline the story before elaborating on the 10 rules.

KEY QUOTES

“I hope you use this book not only to fuel your life, work, and team with positive energy but also to enjoy the ride of your life.”
—Jon Gordon

“Positive people, positive communication, positive interactions, and positive work and team cultures produce positive results.”



Story Outline



The story is about George, a manager at NRG (a lightbulb manufacturing company). George had a great start to his career and a loving family. Yet recently, nothing seemed to be going right, and he felt besieged by problems on all fronts.

- At work, his team had been performing badly and was struggling with an upcoming product launch. George's job was at risk unless he could turn things around quickly.
- At home, his negativity and perpetual sense of doom-and-gloom was making everyone miserable. His wife threatened to leave him if he didn't change.
- George's life seemed to be unraveling in front of him, and he felt helpless and frustrated. When his car broke down and he had to take the bus to work for 2 weeks, George felt like it was the last straw. Could he get any unluckier than this?



Yet, those 2 weeks turned out to be a blessing in disguise. The bus driver, Joy, was a woman full of energy and enthusiasm. After encountering so many passengers who were overworked, overwhelmed, and overstressed, she made it her personal mission to energize each and every passenger on her bus. She called it the "Energy Bus", and it was always full of cheerful passengers.



Initially Joy's exuberance annoyed George, but he soon warmed up to her. Together with the other passengers on the Energy Bus, Joy progressively imparted the "10 rules for the ride of your life" that transformed George's perspectives and attitudes. As he let go of his negativity, things started to change for the better at work and at home.



By the end of 2 weeks, George managed to rally his work team, successfully launch the new product, and renew his relationship with his wife and children. He was amazed at his profound shift, and decided to keep taking the Energy Bus even when his car was repaired.

KEY QUOTES

"Every morning you have a choice. Are you going to be a positive thinker or a negative thinker?"

—Ken Blanchard



The 10 Rules For a Positive, Fulfilling Life

Now, let's look at the 10 rules that led to George's transformation, and the accompanying steps you can take to start applying them.



Rule #1: You're the Driver



Life is like a bus ride. You can only control the journey and destination when you're in the driver's seat.

- Make a real decision to take control of your life. It's your bus, and you get to choose where you go and what kind of ride it will be.
- To create the life you want, you must first know what you want. As the driver, you can ask for advice and directions, but you're ultimately responsible for deciding where to go.



Take some time to crystallize your vision of what you want your life to look like. Write down:

- Your vision for your life (including your health);
- Your vision for your work, career, and team; and
- Your vision for your family and relationships.



Rule #2: Channel your Energy in the Right Place



Everything is made of energy, including physical objects, people, and thoughts. Albert Einstein distilled this concept into the formula $E = MC^2$.

- You can experience this truth in your daily life. The food you eat, the people you hang out with, the words you say, and even the thoughts you think, all energize or de-energize you.



To bring your vision to life, you must first focus on it. This begins with your thoughts.

KEY QUOTES

"If you don't take responsibility for your life and control of your bus then you can't take it where you want to go."

"No one can choose your attitude but you."

"If you want to change your situation you must first change your thoughts."

KEY QUOTES

- Have you ever received a call from someone the moment you think about him/her? This phenomenon is known as “telephone telepathy”. The law of attraction says that thoughts are magnetic. We attract what we think about the most. The more you focus on something, the more it shows up in your life.
- Our thoughts carry energy. When you think about a happy memory or an inspiring vision, it can fill you with joy, motivation and positive energy. Thought energy can be so tangible that you may even read someone’s mind as if the words are being transmitted to you.
- Write down your vision, then spend at least 10 minutes each day visualizing your ideal future.
- At the same time, stop complaining. It distracts you from what you want, sends negative thought energy to attract more negatives, and ruins other passengers’ ride.



Events + Perception = Outcome. You can’t control the events in your life, but you can control how you perceive and respond to them.

- Sometimes, you must experience something you don’t want, in order to realize what you do want. See every challenge or setback as an opportunity for you to grow wiser and stronger.
- Surround yourself with positive people. Use positive energy to overcome challenges to create your desired outcomes.

“Sometimes we have to see what we don’t want, to know what we do want.”

“Positive energy and positive people create positive results.”



Rule #3: Fill the Tank with Positive Energy



It’s not enough to have vision and focus. You also need fuel to get to your desired destination. Positive energy propels your bus forward, while negative energy clogs up your engine.

- When you whine about problems and blame others, you create/spread negative energy that drains and demotivates people. This leads to bad outcomes.
- When you exhibit and spread positive energy, it motivates and energizes people. This leads to success.

“Positive energy is high octane fuel for the ride of your life while negative energy causes sludge to accumulate in your energy pipeline.”

- Imagine you have 2 dogs inside you—a positive dog and a negative dog—battling for dominance. The dog that wins will be the one that you feed more. So, feed the positive dog.

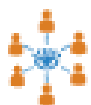


Let go of your negative thoughts and energy, and focus on the positives that you're grateful for. Fill yourself with positive energy first, so you can share it with others.

- There's always a positive to every negative, or a silver lining to every dark cloud. Consciously fill your mind with positive thoughts, so there's no space for negative thoughts to creep in. For example, if you're upset about a flat tire, be thankful that you own a car in the first place. When the restaurant is slow in serving your meal, think of people who're going hungry elsewhere.
- In the story, George learned to crystallize his vision and focus. Thereafter, he was given a book with many 10-minute exercises to give himself positive energy boosts throughout the day. He started to take "thank you walks" to think about what he was grateful for, and ended each day by talking to his children about something good that they experienced that day. Before long, George started to feel better about himself and his life, and others began to see the positive changes in him.



Rule #4: Invite Others on the Journey



With a clear vision/focus for your journey and fuel in your tank, you're now ready to invite people onto your bus, and to share your vision with them. The more positive people you have on the bus, the more you can generate and spread the positive energy.



It was just 1 week to the product launch, and George's team was still in a mess. If they were to have any chance of success, they had to pull things together quickly. Joy advised him to get buy-in by sharing his vision and inviting people to get on the bus with him.

- George followed Joy's recommended steps closely:
 - (i) He sent an email with an electronic bus ticket to his boss and team members to spark their curiosity.

- (ii) Then, he met each person individually to share his vision for the product launch, explain where his bus was going, and invite them to come onboard.
- (iii) He concluded each meeting by giving the person a printed ticket. If they were ready to board the bus, they should return the ticket (with their name on it) the following Monday at 9am.
- (iv) Separately, he also gave a ticket to his wife, with a vision for himself, their marriage, and their family.
- On Monday, George returned to the office in anticipation, only to find that not everyone was willing to get on his bus.
 - (i) Three of his team members believed the product launch would fail, and they didn't want to be a part of it. They preferred to remain on the sidelines as the rest worked on their final preparations.
 - (ii) Surprisingly, 2 of the most troublesome team members submitted their tickets. However, instead of contributing, they only disrupted the meetings with endless criticisms and negativity.

"You haven't failed until you stop trying."



Rule #5: Don't Waste Energy on Those Who Refuse to Board



Between the 3 deserters and 2 trouble-makers, George felt like his bus had stalled before it even started. He was devastated. The next morning, he confided with his fellow passengers on the Energy Bus, and learned the next rule: Don't waste time/energy on people who refuse to come onboard.

- If people don't share your vision and don't want to be on your bus, there's no point having them onboard. It will only ruin the ride for everyone else, and distract you from driving the bus or serving the other passengers.
- Accept that some people will get on your bus and some won't. Don't take it personally. However, speak with each person who refused the ticket, and give them a final chance to come onboard. If their answer is still "no", then exclude them from all meetings and discussions until you can formally remove them from the bus.



Rule #6: Remove the Energy Vampires From Your Bus



There will always be negative people who kill productivity and sabotage your efforts by instilling doubts and fear. They are like energy vampires that suck the life out of you and your passengers.

- Put up a “No Energy Vampires Allowed” sign and remove such people from your bus. Let the energy vampires know that you won’t tolerate negativity. They can either change their attitude and contribute constructively to the shared vision, or get off the bus.



You can only counter others’ criticism if your beliefs, conviction and vision are strong enough to withstand their doubts. You can only counter others’ negativity if you have enough positive energy. This is especially important if the nay-sayers are people you cannot remove from your bus, such as your boss.

- Develop the habit of infusing yourself with positive thinking and positive energy throughout the day.



Equipped with Rules 5 and 6, George got his team in order by confronting the 2 energy vampires and the 3 members who didn’t submit their tickets.

- After a series of 1-1 meetings, 3 of the team members agreed to get on the bus fully to give George and his vision a chance. However, one of the members quit, and another was fired. In the process, George realized how much his own negativity had hurt the team’s morale and productivity in the past. He resolved to be a better leader moving forward.
- With the right people on the bus and a renewed sense of hope, George’s team had their most productive day in months.



Rule #7: Use Enthusiasm to Attract and Retain Passengers



This rule is about leading from the heart, to infect others with your positive energy and emotions.

- Emotions are basically energy in motion. Your emotional state reflects how energy is flowing through you. When you try

KEY QUOTES

“Your positive energy and vision must be greater than anyone’s and everyone’s negativity. Your certainty must be greater than everyone’s doubt.”

“The heart is your power center. It’s where contagious positive leadership comes from.”

to please others or gain their approval, you give away your power. When you bring happiness, gratitude, and excitement to others, you empower everyone. People were found to be stronger and more resilient when they were thinking positive thoughts than when they were thinking negative ones.

- Studies show that emotions are contagious. The heart serves as an emotional conductor—your feelings are broadcasted through your heart's electromagnetic field to every cell in your body and beyond, for up to 5-10 feet. It's easier to feel good when others around you feel good too.



Be a Chief Energy Officer (CEO) to spread courage, optimism, and enthusiasm.

- Your excitement decides if people want to get on your bus and stay there. When you're truly passionate and excited about your life and work, others will feel the energy and want to get on your bus. The more positive people you have onboard, the more your reputation and energy spreads, and the more passengers you'll attract.
- Let your enthusiasm attract passengers and energize them during the ride. Nurture other CEOs who can continue to spread the positive energy throughout your organization and beyond.



Rule #8: Love your Passengers



Besides their strong enthusiasm, great leaders show genuine care and concern for the people around them. When you truly love and care for your team, they will love and care for you back.



Specifically, you can love your passengers in 5 ways:

- Make time for them. Spend quality 1-1 time to engage them and get to know them as individuals. During your interactions, truly *be* with people and give them 100% of your attention—they will be able to feel the difference.
- Listen to them with heart and empathy, so you can truly hear their needs, feelings, ideas, etc.

KEY QUOTES

"Just as every cell in the body beats to the frequency of the heart, everyone around you will beat to your frequency and your energy."

"People are always buying you and your energy."

"A life touches a life that touches a life. It spreads, one person at a time."

- Recognize them by honoring who they are and what they do. Write them a handwritten note, remember their birthdays and things that matter to them (e.g. their kids' names or their anniversaries). Catch people doing the right things and share positive feedback.
- Serve them by helping them to grow, achieve their goals, and enjoy themselves on your bus.
- See and bring out the best in them. Constantly look for value in yourself and in others. See the potential in each person, and help them to shine, succeed, and be happy.



With just days to the product launch, George's team had a lot to do. George set aside his own fears and concerns, and reminded himself to trust fully in himself and his team. Once he let go of his uptight/grumpy self and showed his love and care, things started to fall in place, both at work and at home.



Rule #9: Drive with Purpose



Along the journey, you will inevitably encounter setbacks. Without a purpose, you won't have the energy or motivation to persist. On the other hand, when you're working on something truly meaningful, you'll rarely feel bored or tired.



George gathered his team members to discuss their wider purpose as a team, beyond the upcoming product presentation.

- After a passionate debate, they agreed that their real goal wasn't just to sell lightbulbs, but to:
 - Strive for greatness through great ideas, great marketing campaigns, and great results;
 - Develop Chief Energy Officers within and outside their team to spread positive energy; and
 - Create new possibilities with their lightbulbs, e.g. allow a student to study late for an exam, an elderly person to find his medicine at night, or a working parent to prepare for work before dawn.

KEY QUOTES

"The more you recognize them for doing things right the more they will do things right. Feed the positive dog inside them and watch it grow."

"When you bring out the best in others you can't help bringing out the best in yourself."

"Purpose is the ultimate fuel for our journey through life."

- By the end of the discussion, the energy and excitement in the room was palpable. People were no longer competing for the limelight or pushing for their personal agendas. Instead, they were collaborating to find ways to advance their shared purpose.



Fueled by a new sense of purpose and direction, the team worked tirelessly to finish and polish the launch and presentations. The event was a roaring success. Meanwhile, George's relationship with his wife and children also improved dramatically.



Rule #10: Have Fun and Enjoy the Ride



After just 2 weeks on the Energy Bus, George found himself a changed man. When his car was finally repaired, but he decided to keep taking the Energy Bus to surround himself with positive people, and to contribute to others in need. Joy had 1 final rule left to impart: to have fun and enjoy the ride.

- Most people get so overwhelmed and stressed with work and daily responsibilities that they don't stop to notice or cherish the things and people in their lives. They realize too late at their deathbeds that they've failed to pay attention to what truly matters.
- Have fun on your ride. Appreciate the scenery and enjoy the time with your passengers. Don't rush from 1 destination to the next, or fret over how fast your bus is traveling compared to others.



11 Steps to Start your Energy Bus



Create your vision. Together with your team, develop a shared vision (or multiple visions) for where your bus should be headed. Ask yourselves: What are our goals? What do we see when we look to the future? What do we wish to accomplish?



Find a wider purpose to propel your vision forward. Ask yourselves: How will our vision benefit each team member? How will it benefit others? What do we stand for? What does greatness mean to us? How will we make a difference?

KEY QUOTES

"Shared purpose keeps a team energized and together."

"The goal of every journey should be to arrive at your destination with a smile on your face."

 Consolidate your vision and purpose into a vision statement. Write it down.

 Focus on your vision. Make sure each member has a copy of the vision statement. Encourage them to review the vision daily, and spend at least 10 minutes per day visualizing the desired future.

 Zoom in on the goals and action steps your team must achieve to make the vision a reality. Write these down and share it with the entire team.

 Identify the people required to achieve the goals and vision. Invite them on the bus with a digital or printed ticket.

 Engage and energize your team on a daily basis to spread positive energy and keep negativity at bay. Cultivate practices and processes to develop a positive culture.

 Identify negative team members who are slowing down the bus. Have an open discussion to understand what's going on, why, and agree on a course of action. Try to help them succeed if possible. However, if they're unwilling or unable to change, then get them off the bus.

 Expect detours, obstacles, flat tires, and potholes on the journey. In face of adversity and setbacks, ask yourselves: What can we learn from this incident? How can we grow and bounce back stronger? What opportunity does this challenge present?

 Show your passengers that you care for them. Find ways to recognize them, spend quality time with them, listen to them, serve them and their growth, and bring out the best in them.

 Have fun on the journey, and enjoy the ride! Ask yourselves: how can we succeed and have fun in the process? How can we infuse more joy into our work?



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

This story was inspired by a true experience by author Jon Gordon, when he met a bus driver who impacted him with his positive energy and wisdom. The story is written in a lively and engaging

KEY QUOTES

"Every person and every team will be tested on their journey. It was part of the curriculum of life."

"You have only one ride through life so give it all you got and enjoy the ride."

style, with bits of facts, anecdotes and research incorporated throughout the story. For more details, please visit www.theenergybus.com. You can also get more tips and resources from www.jongordon.com.



About the Authors

Ken Blanchard, PhD is one of the most influential leadership experts in the world. He has co-authored 60 books. In 2005 he was inducted into Amazon's Hall of Fame as one of the top 25 bestselling authors of all time. He's also the recipient of numerous leadership awards and honors. Together with his wife, Margie, Ken founded The Ken Blanchard Companies, a leading international training and consulting firm.



Jon Gordon, is an author, speaker, trainer and consultant focusing on leadership, culture, sales, and teamwork. He holds a Bachelor of Science in human ecology from Cornell University and a Master of Arts in teaching from Emory University.

KEY QUOTES